Know Thyself: My Journey of Self-Discovery as a College Freshman

At this stage of my life, “know thyself” has become more than just a philosophical phrase, it’s a phrase that constantly lingers in my mind. As a college freshman, I am faced with new situations, responsibilities, and decisions that enable or force me to think beyond. For me, knowing myself means being aware of my strengths, weaknesses, values, and emotions, while also accepting that I am still a work in progress. Truly, it is not about having everything figured out, but about being honest with who I am right now.

Entering college has significantly changed how I view myself. In high school, I was comfortable because everything felt familiar, I’ve known the place because it is my hometown, the environment, my classmates, and even my routine. But now that I am in college, it pushed me out of that comfort zone. I had to meet new people, adapt to the academic system, and manage my time more independently. There were moments when I doubted myself, I doubted if I really can do this course, this choice I chose, and more. These things made me question who I really am or who I really want to become.

One personal experience that stood out was during my first month in calculus 1. I struggled to keep up with the class and lectures, it really hit me to the core and made me question my abilities, my choice, even my life. That very experience still haunts me and troubles me. At that point I felt like all the problem in this world weighs on me, morning feels like sleepless night, everything just feels like unfavorable to me, but then I realize that I’ve got to pick myself up, move forward and do better. I understood that moment that I am not a machine, I am simply human and human problems needs human solution, humans stumble down, get back up and face tomorrow. Socrates believed that self-knowledge is the foundation of a good and ethical life and I feel like I am still not there but trying. For me, it’s not about having no fear but accepting fear and overcoming it.

Through this process of reflection, I have discovered several things about myself. One of my strengths is resilience, I may struggle at first, but the thought of giving up doesn’t come to my mind. I value growth and genuinely want to improve. I’ve also come to realize my weaknesses such as procrastination, self-doubt, and sometimes comparing myself too much to others. These realizations are not easy to accept, but they are necessary if I want to grow. I feel like acknowledging your weakness is proof that you’re trying to be improve and turn weakness to strength.

The concept from Socrates’ idea of “know thyself.” Socrates believed that self-knowledge is the foundation of wisdom and that an unexamined life is not worth living. Reflecting on this idea, I realized that true growth comes from questioning myself, including my choices, my habits, and my beliefs. That instead of avoiding my flaws or mistakes, I am learning to face them honestly. This perspective encourages me to be more aware of my actions and to take responsibility for becoming a better version of myself.

Overall, my journey as a college first year is teaching me that self-discovery is an ongoing journey. Knowing myself is a continuous effort to reflect, learn, and grow. I am beginning to accept that it is okay to feel uncertain at times because those moments often lead to deeper understanding.